



Centre Georges Pompidou

A high-tech structure with inside-out construction that startled its Parisian neighbors

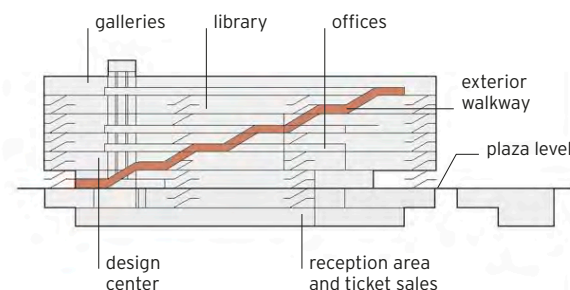
Most French presidents like to leave their own architectural mark on Paris, none more so than Georges Pompidou, Gaullist prime minister from 1962 to 1968 and president from 1969 until 1974. It is ironic that this conservative statesman is associated with one of the most radical, futuristic buildings of the age. Designed by Briton Richard Rogers and Italian Renzo Piano, the building established Rogers's signature mark of exposing a building's services, such as water and air conditioning, in pipes on the outside. Rudely, some critics dubbed this style Bowellism, and the building was unpopular in many architectural circles when it opened in 1977.

An artistic success story

The building—known colloquially as the Beaubourg due to the area of Paris in which it stands—is 149 ft (45.5m) tall. Its outer framework is covered with brightly colored pipes, ducts, and external elevators. Inside, the building houses the largest modern art museum in Europe, an experimental music center, and a library.

A SIMPLE BOX

While the Centre Georges Pompidou is highly decorated outside, its inside is relatively straightforward. Two basement levels house reception areas and ticket sales; the six floors above contain galleries, cinemas, restaurants, a library, offices, and a bookstore. With the load-bearing structures restricted to the outer framework, all the floors are open plan and can be divided up and reorganized at will for maximum flexibility.



More than **16,500 tons (15,000 tonnes)** of steel were used to construct the **metal framework**



◁ COLOR CODED

The exterior pipes are all color coded: white for ventilation, blue for air conditioning, green for plumbing, and yellow for electricity. The exterior stairs and elevators are red.

▷ INSIDE-OUT

The external clutter of structural towers and supports, stairs, elevators and escalators, and service pipes obscures the outside of the building but ensures that the inside is kept clear for exhibitions and other uses.

